government. So elections had to be carried out to form a new government and convene a new parliament. Holding a successful election in 2015 was the top priority of the UEC, and for U Thein Sein's government as well. the president stressed his commitment to conducting free and fair elections in his monthly radio talk, stating that "my government under its executive authority and within the bounds of its executive power, will ensure that the elections are free and fair" (Thein Sein 2015).

Although the president promised to hold a free and fair election, people still mistrusted the government and did not think that the UEC could do its work credibly, given its record in 2010. Moreover, 2015 was a critical year for Myanmar for many other reasons. The country had to sign a nationwide ceasefire agreement (see Su Mon Thazin Aung, this volume), rehabilitate flood victims, solve the problems of labour and student strikes and land grabbing issues, among other things (see Pedersen 2014). Many were worried the election would be marred by violence in some areas, due to rising nationalism and religious extremism. Under these complex circumstances, the UEC had to tackle a range of issues and challenges in the pre-election period.

The UEC would not easily convince political parties or civil society organizations (CSOs) to trust it. To address the trust deficit, the UEC launched an information centre in Yangon and a new website on 27 May 2015 where eligible voters could check their names against voting lists compiled by the commission.[5] Meeting with the Myanmar Press Council and CSOs to discuss a draft Code of Conduct for observers and political parties, it sought to demonstrate its willingness to conduct a free and fair election. The draft code was discussed with the over sixty local CSOs and international organizations in December 2014. About two-thirds of the original code was changed in line with CSOs' requests.

The poor capacity of the UEC and its staff was one of the biggest challenges. Chairman U Tin Aye frankly admitted in interviews on Skynet News during October 2015 that the UEC could not manage at the two lowest tiers of administration, the township and ward or village levels, due to a shortage of staff (Skynet 2015). Although it had been recruiting through the Union Civil Services Training, these new staff would become available only after mid-2016. He explained that mistakes happened because of poor management, and expressed concerns about the difficulties of capacity building and the material limitations of the UEC. Therefore, he encouraged international and local donors to supply basic needs for the UEC staff.